

Earn from Abroad, Work from India

The Complete Guide for Students and Developers

Every legitimate way to earn in dollars, euros, pounds or dirhams while living in India — with the exact websites, what they pay, who can join, how to get paid, and the Indian tax and FEMA rules that apply.

As of 4 October 2026 · Combines “Global Remote Work Roadmap” and “Earn from Abroad While You Study”, plus new research · Conversions use ₹96 = \$1 · Rates and rules change often — always check the website before signing up

How to read the tags: **STUDENT** good while studying or as a fresher · **EXPERIENCED** needs 2+ years of real work · **ANY** no tech background needed · **NEW** not in the earlier PDFs

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PART A — START HERE

1. Read this first — the rules that protect you

- ☐ **Be 18 or older.** Most platforms (Upwork, Medium, UserTesting, GSoC, LFX, Outreachy and others) require it. Under 18? Focus on learning, free programs and portfolio projects for now.
- ☐ **Use your own identity only.** Your own name, PAN and bank account. Never “rent” an account or let someone work under your name — accounts get banned and it can be illegal.
- ☐ **Never pay to get work.** Real platforms don’t charge joining, training or “activation” fees (Section 24).
- ☐ **Stay honest.** No fake reviews, no fake experience, no proxy interviews, and never do other students’ graded assignments or exams — that is cheating, not tutoring.
- ☐ **Check your rules.** Students: your college or scholarship rules. Employees: your employment contract (below).
- ☐ **Start small.** 5–10 hours a week at first. Money from abroad is taxable — keep records from day one (Section 23).

Working professionals: the moonlighting check

No central law in India bans moonlighting for private-sector employees, but breaching your contract’s exclusivity or non-compete clause is a breach of contract — the risk is termination, not jail ([GUVI explainer](#)). Companies can spot dual employment through PF/UAN records and AIS/26AS.

- ☐ Read your offer letter for “exclusivity”, “outside employment”, “conflict of interest” and “IP assignment” clauses
- ☐ If it says “prior approval”, get approval from HR in writing
- ☐ Never work for your employer’s competitors or clients, and never use office laptops, office hours or office code
- ☐ Take contractor (freelance) work — not PF-registered employment at a second company

2. Quick map — every path on one page

Path	Level	First money	Pay signal	Main websites
Freelance marketplaces	STUDENT	1–3 months	Starts low, grows with reviews	Upwork , Fiverr , Freelancer.com , Contra
Vetted talent networks	EXPERIENCED	3–8 weeks	Highest rates; Toptal \$60–150/hr reported	Toptal , Arc , Turing , Braintrust
Remote jobs & internships	STUDENT	1–3 months	Stipend / salary; India senior remote devs expect ~\$62,743/yr (Arc)	Wellfound , LinkedIn , Himalayas , WWR
Direct clients / white-label	EXPERIENCED	2–4 months	No platform cut; monthly retainers	Clutch , LinkedIn
AI training	STUDENT	1–3 weeks	Outlier India coding \$13.25–27.5/hr	Outlier , Alignerr , Mercor
Testing & user research	ANY	2–6 weeks	UserTesting ~\$10 per 20-min test	uTest , Testlio , UserTesting
Teaching & tutoring	ANY	2–6 weeks	Cambly ~\$10/hr; Preply/italki: you set price	Preply , italki , Cambly , Codingal
Mentoring & courses	EXPERIENCED	2–6 weeks	You set price; Udemy 97% via your link	MentorCruise , Topmate , Udemy
Writing & YouTube	STUDENT	1–6 months	Tech articles ~\$200–578 each	Medium , Draft.dev , YouTube
Translation, transcription, voice	ANY	2–6 weeks	GoTranscript \$0.50–1.20 per audio minute	GoTranscript , Rev , Voice123
Design, products & apps	STUDENT	1–6 months	Per sale or contest	99designs , Etsy , Envato
Bug bounty	STUDENT (slow)	3–12 months	Low/medium bugs ~\$100–500	HackerOne , Bugcrowd , Intigriti
Paid open source	STUDENT	Per term	Outreachy \$7,000; Summer of Bitcoin \$3,000–6,600; LFX India \$1,300	Outreachy , GSoC , Summer of Bitcoin
Hackathons & competitions	STUDENT	Per event	Prize money varies	Devpost , Kaggle , Topcoder
Expert calls & consulting	EXPERIENCED	Irregular	\$100–500/hr calls	GLG , AlphaSights , Guidepoint
Professional services (non-dev)	ANY + certification	1–6 months	Depends on certification	AAPC jobs , QuickBooks ProAdvisor , IRS EA

3. How outsourcing actually works

US, European, Gulf and Australian companies send work to India through five routes. Four of them are open to an individual — your first decision is which route you are standing on.

Route	How the work reaches you	Your position	Examples
IT services firms	A large company wins the contract and staffs it with employees	Employee (INR salary)	TCS, Infosys, GCCs in India
Talent networks / staff augmentation	The platform vets you, then places you on a contract with a foreign client	Contractor (USD)	Toptal, Turing, Arc, Uplers
Freelance marketplaces	A client posts a job; you send a proposal	Freelancer (USD/EUR)	Upwork, Fiverr, Freelancer.com

White-label subcontracting	A foreign agency's overflow work, delivered under its name	Subcontractor	Agencies listed on Clutch
Direct remote hiring	The company hires you directly; an EOR like Deel runs payroll	Remote employee or contractor	Remote OK, Wellfound jobs

Why it pays: per [Arc's data](#), remote developers in India expect \$48,918/yr on average (senior: \$62,743), while the US average on Arc's [global page](#) is \$96,999. Even at half the US rate you save the client money — and earn very well by Indian standards.

What foreign clients actually want

- **Timezone overlap** — many Turing contracts ask for 4 hours of overlap with US Pacific time (Section 4).
- **Clear English** — Toptal's very first screening stage is an English and communication interview.
- **Proof, not promises** — live projects, GitHub, and short case studies (problem → solution → result with numbers).
- **Async habits** — written updates, Loom videos, tidy pull requests.

4. Country & timezone guide NEW

The client's country decides *when* you work and *what* sells. India (UTC+5:30) is well placed: same working day as the Gulf, afternoon overlap with Europe, and the US morning falls in your evening.

Region	Time vs IST	What sells well	Region-specific websites / notes
US / Canada	9.5–13.5 hrs behind	Software, night-shift support, US tax prep, medical billing & coding, SAT/AP tutoring, kids coding classes	Biggest market: Upwork, Toptal, LinkedIn. Fill W-8BEN for US clients (Section 23).
UK / Ireland	4.5–5.5 hrs behind	Agency white-label work, Xero/Sage bookkeeping, GCSE/A-level tutoring	PeoplePerHour (UK-based); easiest overlap — your afternoon/evening
EU	3.5–4.5 hrs behind	GDPR-aware development, SAP, data work; German/French language premium	Malt lists India as an “open country” for registration (business/sole-trader documents needed)
Gulf (UAE, Saudi, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman, Bahrain)	1.5–2.5 hrs behind	CBSE/IB tuition for diaspora kids, Hindi/regional languages, Arabic–English websites, e-commerce, Zoho/Odoo	Ureed (MENA marketplace, open worldwide, 15% fee); Bayt for jobs; many clients come via referrals and parent WhatsApp groups
Australia / NZ	2.5–7.5 hrs ahead	Virtual assistants (real estate is a big niche), Xero bookkeeping, HSC/VCE tutoring	Freelancer.com is Australian; your morning = their afternoon
Japan / Singapore	2.5–3.5 hrs ahead	“Bridge” engineers who speak Japanese (JLPT N2/N1) are paid a premium	Learn Japanese via the JLPT path; see Japanese-language jobs in India
Russia	2.5 hrs behind	—	Be careful. PayPal, Payoneer and Upwork cut off Russian operations after 2022 sanctions, so payments are hard (freelancepayouts). Accept money only through a proper bank channel, after checking with your bank; never from sanctioned entities.

Best work slots from India: Gulf — normal office hours · UK/EU — 1 pm to 10 pm IST · US East Coast — 7 pm to 1 am IST · Australia — 6 am to 1 pm IST.

5. Freelance marketplaces STUDENT

Clients post jobs and you send proposals, or you sell fixed “gigs”. For developers, Upwork is the most useful (hourly work and repeat clients); use Fiverr when you can sell a clear package.

Website	Best for	Fee / note
Upwork	Hourly + fixed-price projects, repeat clients	0–15% per contract, shown before you apply and locked for that contract (Upwork help); proposals cost Connects (\$0.15 each)
Fiverr	Fixed packages (“I will fix your React bug in 24h”)	Flat 20% (tips included); money held ~14 days (7 for Top Rated)
Freelancer.com	Bidding and contests	~10% or \$5 minimum on the free plan; many low-budget jobs
PeoplePerHour	UK/EU clients	20% → 7.5% → 3.5% as billings with a client grow
Contra	Portfolio + invoicing your own clients	0% commission for freelancers
Guru	Mid-size projects, lower competition	Check current fees
Malt NEW	European clients (France, Germany, Spain...)	India is an “open country”; registration needs business or sole-trader documents
Ureed NEW	Gulf / Arab-world clients; tech, design, translation	Open worldwide; 15% fee; withdrawal minimum \$70 (PayPal/Payoneer) or \$100 (bank)

Gig ideas clients actually buy

- **Beginners:** Figma/PSD → responsive HTML/React page · landing pages for small businesses · WordPress/Shopify fixes and speed work · Python scraping and Excel/CSV cleaning · simple Chrome extensions · Google Sheets / Apps Script automations
- **Experienced:** Next.js/Node SaaS MVPs · Stripe/Razorpay integrations · admin dashboards · adding AI features (LLM APIs, RAG chatbots) · AI automations with n8n/Make/Zapier · performance and security audits

How to win your first clients

1. **Pick a niche.** “React & Next.js developer — landing pages and bug fixes”, not “full-stack developer”. Upwork lets you create several specialized profiles.
2. **Show proof.** 3–5 live projects, each with problem → what you built → result; add a 60–90 second intro video.
3. **Be fast and personal.** Apply within the first hour; your first two lines should restate the client’s problem and ask one specific question.
4. **Price for reviews first.** Take the first 3–5 jobs a little cheaper, then raise rates every 2–3 contracts. Work backwards from your net target (at a 10% fee, charge \$22.22 to net \$20; on Fiverr list a gig at \$100 to net \$80).
5. **Use fixed packages.** Upwork’s Project Catalog and Fiverr gigs let clients buy without bidding.
6. **Never move a client off-platform** — it breaks the rules and removes payment protection. For clients you met elsewhere, Upwork has Direct Contracts / Any Hire.

6. Vetted talent networks & long contracts EXPERIENCED

These test you once, then place you with US/EU clients — no bidding and much higher rates. Screening is tough and most roles want 20–40 hours a week.

Website	India?	Fee to you	Commitment	Pay signal	Screening
Toptal	Yes	0% (client markup)	~20 hr/week minimum reported	\$60–150/hr reported	English call → algorithm test → live coding → test project; 3–8 weeks; ~3% accepted

Turing	Yes	You set your rate	Often 40 hr/week + 4 hr PST overlap; some short contracts	USD contracts	Online tests + interview
Arc.dev	Yes	0%	Freelance 20–40 hr/week, 4 weeks–1 year	Arc says \$60–100+/hr typical	Profile + technical vetting
Braintrust	Yes	0% (client pays 15%)	Per project	You set your rate	Application review
Crossover	Yes	—	Full-time, 40 hr/week	Senior Full-Stack listed at \$100,000/yr (\$50/hr)	Long skill tests
Uplers	India talent only	—	Full-time / contract-to-hire	Roles on Uplers' payroll	AI + human evaluation
Lemon.io	No (most of Asia excluded)	Not open to India-based developers (NoDesk)			

4-week screening prep

1. Week 1 — arrays, hashing, two pointers, sliding window; timed practice (45 min per problem).
2. Week 2 — trees, graphs, BFS/DFS, basic DP; one mock live-coding session a day (talk while you code).
3. Week 3 — a small take-home-style project: auth + CRUD + tests + Docker + README, deployed.
4. Week 4 — English mock answers (“a hard bug you fixed”, “a project you led”) in 2-minute STAR format.

Toptal makes you wait about 6 months after a failed attempt, so apply only when ready. Braintrust’s client pays the fee, so you can price a little higher there.

7. Remote jobs, internships & the ATS trick STUDENT

Job boards lead to direct contracts, remote internships and full-time jobs with zero platform fees — but many listings are “US only” or “EU only”. Filter hard, and apply on the company’s own careers page.

Website	Best for	Tip
Wellfound	Startup jobs and internships; message founders	Try location “Remote” and “India”
LinkedIn Jobs	Highest volume	Remote + Contract/Internship filters; add “APAC” to keywords
Internshala	Work-from-home internships (mostly Indian, some international)	Good for your first internship certificate
Himalayas	Remote-only, best timezone filters	Choose UTC+5:30
We Work Remotely	Curated remote tech jobs	“Anywhere in the World” category
Remote OK	High-volume remote tech jobs, salaries shown	“Worldwide” filter
Arc.dev	Developer jobs, freelance + full-time	Country filter: India
Work at a Startup (YC)	Y Combinator startups	Many roles are US-only; filter for remote
Bayt NEW	Gulf (UAE, Saudi, Qatar) jobs	Look for “remote” roles
HN “Who is hiring?”	Monthly thread (1st of each month) where founders post jobs	Search the thread for “REMOTE (Worldwide)” or “India”

The ATS trick — paste into Google, then filter “Past week”

```
site:job-boards.greenhouse.io OR site:boards.greenhouse.io "remote" ("India" OR "APAC") ("full stack" OR intern)
site:jobs.lever.co "remote" ("India" OR "anywhere") ("full stack" OR "backend" OR "junior")
site:jobs.ashbyhq.com "remote" ("India" OR "APAC") engineer
site:apply.workable.com "remote" "India" developer
```

Apply when a listing says “Worldwide”, “Anywhere”, “APAC”, “India” or “UTC+5:30 ±3”; skip “must be authorized to work in the US”.

Getting shortlisted

1. One-page resume; every bullet = action + tech + measurable result (“Cut API latency 40% by...”).
2. Top line: “Based in India (IST) — 4+ hours overlap with US East / full overlap with EU”.
3. GitHub, 2 live projects and LinkedIn fully up to date.
4. A 3–4 line custom note per application — no generic cover letters.
5. A short LinkedIn message to the hiring manager with the application link and one relevant project.

How contract jobs pay: most companies pay foreign contractors through Deel, Remote or Oyster. Per [Deel's help page](#), a local bank transfer is \$0 and SWIFT is \$5–10, with Wise and Payoneer as options — currency conversion is charged separately, so compare routes (Section 22).

8. Direct clients & white-label work EXPERIENCED

Once you have 3–5 good reviews or case studies, direct clients pay the most — no 10–20% platform cut, and monthly retainers become possible.

Model	Client	How to find them	Payment
White-label subcontractor	Small US/UK/EU agencies with overflow work	Clutch / GoodFirms agency lists; email or LinkedIn the founder	Usually net-15/30 from delivery acceptance
Direct small-business / startup client	Founders, small businesses	LinkedIn posts + outreach, referrals, clients who “graduate” from Upwork	Milestones; 30–50% upfront from new clients

In white-label work the agency keeps the client relationship and you deliver under its name; payment terms should count from delivery acceptance, not from when the agency is paid ([CODERCOPS guide](#)).

```
Subject: Overflow dev capacity for [Agency] – Next.js / Node

Hi [Name], saw [specific project] on your site – nice work.
I'm a full-stack dev in India (Next.js/Node/Postgres) and I help agencies
ship custom features when their team is full. I work white-label, sign your
NDA, and overlap 4 hrs with US East.
Recent: [one-line result]. Open to a small paid test task this month?
– [Name] · [portfolio link]
```

Every contract should state

- Scope, and what is *not* included · change requests = a new quote
- Milestones with an amount for each (in USD/EUR) · upfront %, net-15/30, late-payment rule
- IP transfers “on full payment” · NDA, with any non-compete kept narrow

9. AI training work STUDENT (coding track needs real skill)

AI companies pay people to write, review and rank AI answers and code. It is the fastest dollar income to start from India, but work comes and goes — treat it as extra income, not a salary.

Website	Open to India?	Pay signal	Note
Outlier (Scale AI)	Yes — India-only coding listing	India coding experts: \$13.25–27.5/hr on its listing	Generalist India rates are much lower; weekly pay (PayPal/AirTM)
Mercor	Role-dependent (many generalist roles US-only)	Software roles \$70–200/hr listed	Very selective; AI interview; time-tracking software
Alignerr	Global	Published average ~\$80/hr (Sep 2026)	Coding, STEM, language; paid via Deel

micro1	Global	\$20–150/hr reported	AI-interview vetting
Turing	Yes	USD contracts	Some 5-week, 40 hr/week contracts
Appen , TELUS Digital , Toloka	Yes (wide coverage)	Lower pay	Easier entry; good for non-coders

Not available from India: DataAnnotation.tech (reportedly only US, CA, UK, IE, AU, NZ). Remotasks is winding down. Anyone on WhatsApp/Telegram asking you to pay to “join Outlier” is a scammer.

Tips: take the specialist/coding assessment, not the generalist queue · read instructions twice and write clear reasoning · accuracy before speed (your quality score controls your rate and access) · stay on 3–4 platforms so work keeps flowing · count unpaid onboarding time when judging pay.

10. Software testing & user research ANY

Companies pay people worldwide to find bugs and to give spoken feedback on websites and apps. Good for careful students and non-coders.

Website	How it pays
uTest (Applause)	Per approved bug, graded by value; free uTest Academy to learn
Test IO	Per bug/test by severity and device; paid once the team leader accepts your bug
Testlio	By the hour (not per bug); weekly via Payoneer or PayPal; open to beginners from non-sanctioned countries
UserTesting NEW	Speak your thoughts while using a website: ~\$10 per 15–20 min test, \$4 short tests, \$30–120 live interviews; PayPal; 18+, laptop + mic; India reported eligible, typically 2–5 invites a week (guide)

11. Teaching & tutoring ANY

Teach maths, coding, CS, English or Indian languages to students in the US, UK, Gulf and Australia, and to Indian-diaspora families. Explain and guide — never do a student’s graded work.

Website	What you teach	Pay / note
Preply	Languages + academic subjects (maths, CS); students worldwide	You set your hourly rate; trial lessons matter
italki	Languages: English, Hindi and other Indian languages	Hindi/regional languages for diaspora learners are a strong niche
Cambly NEW	Conversational English with adults; Cambly Kids	No country restriction if your English is fluent; fixed \$0.17/min (~₹850/hr); Kids \$0.20/min needs a degree (Supatutor)
Codingal NEW	AI & coding, maths, public speaking for ages 6–17 in 135 countries	Paid in INR; Codingal says teachers average ₹46,000/month (highest ₹1,85,000)
BrightChamps NEW	Coding, maths, science, English, financial literacy, GenAI for ages 6–16	Paid per session; some roles are US night shifts; listings often ask for 2+ years’ experience
Cuemath	Maths (and coding) for kids in India and abroad	India-based tutors, INR; Cuemath says ₹1,00,000+/month is possible with enough students
Superprof	Any subject, profile-based	Students contact you directly

Not open to India: Outschool (teachers must live in the US, Mexico, Canada, Australia, NZ, South Korea, Spain or the UK). Chegg has closed new expert sign-ups.

High-value niches: SAT/AP/IB and GCSE/A-level maths · CBSE/IB tuition for Gulf families · Python/web coding for teens · spoken English · Hindi for second-generation diaspora kids.

12. Mentoring, courses & interviewing EXPERIENCED

Website	What you sell	Platform cut / note
MentorCruise	Monthly mentorship plans (calls + chat + code review)	Adds ~20% on top of your price; minimum \$20 fee on plans under \$100 (fees)
Codementor	Live debugging help, freelance jobs	Platform fee 13–22% by weekly activity; sessions often \$8–30 per 15 min
Topmate	1:1 calls, resume reviews, mock interviews, digital products	10% via your own link, 20% via Topmate's marketplace; international cards add ~3% + FX
Udemy	Recorded courses	97% of sales via your own coupon/link, 37% organic; subscription pool 15% (Jan 2026)
Karat	Freelance technical interviewing (Interview Engineer)	Separate India listing; per-interview pay on your own schedule
ADPList	Free mentoring	No money — use it to collect your first reviews

Ready-made offers: “junior to job-ready” monthly mentorship · 60-minute mock interview + written feedback · portfolio/code review report · a 4–6 hour mini-course of what you already teach (sell it with your own Udemy link).

13. Writing, content & YouTube STUDENT

Website	What for / note
Medium Partner Program	Earn from member reads; India eligible; must be 18+ and a paying Medium member
Draft.dev	Technical content agency; ~\$315–578 per article
Smashing Magazine	Frontend/UX articles; ~\$200–250 each
DigitalOcean	Paid tutorials (the program pauses at times)
Paid writing list (GitHub)	Big list of companies with paid writer programs
YouTube Partner Program NEW	Fan-funding tier: 500 subscribers, 3 uploads in 90 days, plus 3,000 watch hours in 12 months or 3M Shorts views in 90 days. Ad revenue tier: 1,000 subscribers plus 4,000 watch hours or 10M Shorts views in 90 days (vidIQ)

Write 2–3 strong posts on your own blog first and use them as pitch samples. Coding tutorials in Hindi with English titles reach both Indian and diaspora viewers.

Google Season of Docs (paid docs for open-source projects) has ended — it ran 2019–2024 ([Google](#)). Ignore old articles that list it.

14. Translation, transcription & voice-over ANY NEW

If you speak Hindi or another Indian language well, there is paid work typing out audio, subtitling, translating and recording voice-overs for foreign companies.

Website	Work	Pay / note
GoTranscript	Transcription in Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Bengali, Indian English and more	\$0.50–1.20 per audio minute (up to \$1.75 specialised); weekly via PayPal, Payoneer or USDC; short test to join
Rev	Transcription, captions, foreign-language subtitles	\$0.40–1.10 per minute (transcripts), subtitles \$1.70–4.00+; weekly via PayPal; check eligibility at signup
Ureed	Translation and localisation for Gulf/MENA clients	15% fee; Arabic + English + Hindi/Urdu is a strong combination

Voice123	Voice-over auditions (Hindi and Indian-accent English)	Many India-based voice actors list here
Voices.com	Voice-over marketplace	Has an Indian-accent category; you need a decent mic and a quiet room

15. Design, digital products & apps STUDENT

Build something once and sell it many times — templates, UI kits, plugins, extensions, apps — or win design work.

Website	What for / note
99designs NEW	Logo/web design contests and projects; curated application reviewed in ~7 days, two attempts allowed; paid via Hyperwallet (99designs)
Dribbble , Behance	Design portfolios; clients and design job boards find you here
Etsy	Digital downloads (Notion/resume templates, planners); India sellers supported (Etsy India)
Envato (ThemeForest, CodeCanyon)	Themes, scripts, plugins; revenue share is now a flat 50%
Chrome Web Store	Browser extensions (free, or paid via your own payment system)
Google Play Console / Apple Developer	Mobile apps with ads, subscriptions or paid downloads; Google charges a one-time \$25 registration, Apple \$99 a year

16. Bug bounty & web3 bounties STUDENT (slow start)

Find security bugs inside a company's published scope and get paid. Expect little or no money for the first 3–6 months. India has the 2nd-most researchers on HackerOne ([3university](#)).

Website	What for
PortSwigger Academy , Hacker101	Free learning labs — start here
HackerOne	Largest platform; private invites are where the money is
Intigriti	EU programs, fast triage, beginner-friendly
Bugcrowd	Steady programs, Bugcrowd University
YesWeHack	EU + APAC programs
Immunefi NEW	Smart-contract / web3 security bounties (a different skill set)
Superteam India NEW	Solana ecosystem bounties and grants (dev, design, writing), often paid in USDC

6-month roadmap: Month 1 — HTTP, cookies, sessions, CORS, JWT/OAuth, Burp Suite · Month 2 — PortSwigger labs (access control, IDOR, XSS, SSRF) · Month 3 — first public programs on HackerOne/Intigriti · Month 4 — recon (subdomains, JS endpoints) · Month 5 — business-logic bugs · Month 6 — build reputation for private invites.

Test only inside a program's scope — testing outside it can be illegal. Never download or leak real users' data. **Crypto payments:** income received in crypto is taxed at its INR value when received; selling crypto later attracts 30% tax on gains, 1% TDS, and losses can't be set off ([ClearTax](#)). Keep records of every receipt.

17. Paid open-source programs STUDENT

Stipends in dollars for about three months of real contributions — and they look excellent on a resume. Start contributing to your target project 1–2 months before applications open.

Program	Money	Who can apply	When
Outreachy	\$7,000 for the 3-month internship	18+, people under-represented in tech (e.g. women, non-binary people); 30 hr/week; students need 42 days free of classes and exams	Indian students apply for the May round (initial applications in early February)
GSoC	Country-adjusted; depends on project size	18+, students or open-source beginners (<2 years in OSS)	Contributor applications around March
Summer of Bitcoin NEW	\$3,000–6,600 by location (PPP), paid in bitcoin unless you ask for local currency	University students	About mid-June to late August; 40% after first evaluation, 60% at the end
LFX Mentorship	\$1,300 for India (terms starting from July 2026)	18+, open to all	3 terms a year, ~12 weeks each
Algora	GitHub bounties paid on merge (2026 awards ~\$50–2,500)	Anyone	Year-round; AI agents compete too — pick older bounties with no solid PR
GitHub Sponsors	Monthly sponsorships; India supported, paid in INR	Maintainers of useful projects	Year-round
Hacktoberfest , GSSoC	No money (rewards/certificates)	Beginners	Practice before GSoC/LFX

GSoC note: per Google's FAQ, regular open-source contributors aren't "beginners", but work started on a project while preparing for GSoC is fine — so a working developer new to open source can still be eligible.

18. Hackathons & competitions [STUDENT](#)

Website	What for
Devpost	Online hackathons by global companies, many with cash prizes
MLH	Student hackathons worldwide
Kaggle	Data science / ML competitions with prize pools
Topcoder	Paid development, design and algorithm challenges
HackerEarth , Unstoppable	Hackathons and hiring challenges (India + global companies)

Read each event's eligibility rules — some prizes are limited to certain countries. Even without prize money, finalist spots lead to internships.

19. Consulting & expert networks [EXPERIENCED](#)

Investors and consulting firms pay for one-hour calls with people who really work in an industry. Clients often pay networks \$400–1,500/hr; experts typically get \$100–250/hr (individual contributors) to \$300–500/hr (VP level) ([Mycrolance](#)).

Website	How to join
GLG	Create an expert profile; invites come based on your LinkedIn
AlphaSights	Their team reaches out via LinkedIn; keep your profile detailed
Guidepoint	Expert sign-up form + screening questions

Steadier option: fixed-price tech consulting for non-technical founders — codebase audits, architecture reviews, due diligence on outsourced code, or a fractional tech-lead retainer (8–10 hr/month). Never share confidential information from any employer.

20. Non-developer professional services ANY NEW

Foreign businesses outsource much more than code to India. Your classmates, friends and colleagues from commerce, medical, legal or design backgrounds can use these paths too.

Service	What clients buy	Where to start
Virtual assistant & support	Inbox and calendar management, research, chat/email support, CRM updates (Australian real-estate agencies are a big niche)	Upwork, Fiverr, LinkedIn; learn HubSpot or Zoho CRM
Bookkeeping	QuickBooks (US) and Xero (UK/AU/NZ) books, payroll, accounts payable/receivable	QuickBooks ProAdvisor (free programme membership) and Xero certifications, then Upwork/agencies
US tax preparation	US CPA firms outsource tax-return preparation to India (busy season Jan–Apr) (VJM Global)	The IRS Enrolled Agent exam (3 parts) can now be taken in 40+ Indian cities via PSI (Miles Education)
Medical billing & coding	US healthcare revenue-cycle work: coding diagnoses and procedures, claims	AAPC CPC certification; AAPC remote jobs board ; Indian RCM companies
Legal support	Document review, contract summaries, legal research, patent searching (law graduates)	LinkedIn, legal-process outsourcing firms, Upwork
Engineering drafting	AutoCAD/Revit drafting, BIM, MEP drawings for US/UK/Gulf firms	Autodesk certification , Upwork, white-label firms
Digital marketing	SEO, Google/Meta ads, email marketing, social media	Free Google Skillshop and HubSpot Academy certificates, then Upwork/Fiverr
Video & creative	Video editing for YouTubers and podcasts, thumbnails, motion graphics	Fiverr, Upwork, Contra; show 3 before/after samples

21. Certifications that raise your rate NEW

Foreign clients can't judge your college, but they recognise global certificates. Pick one that matches the service you sell — many are free.

Certification	Cost	Helps with
AWS Skill Builder → AWS certifications	Training free; exams paid	Cloud/DevOps contracts
Salesforce Trailhead	Learning free; certifications paid	Salesforce admin/developer work (very common outsourced work)
HubSpot Academy	Free	CRM, marketing and sales operations
Google Skillshop	Free	Google Ads and Analytics clients
QuickBooks ProAdvisor , Xero certification	Free / low-cost via partner programmes	US / UK / Australian bookkeeping
IRS Enrolled Agent	Exam fees per part	US tax preparation and representation
AAPC CPC	Paid	US medical coding
JLPT (Japanese N2/N1)	Exam fee	Japan “bridge” engineer roles

PART C — MONEY, TAX & SAFETY

22. Getting paid in India

Take marketplace money through the marketplace's own route (Upwork bank transfer / Payoneer). For direct clients, use a flat-fee India-focused receiver or Wise Business; keep PayPal as the last resort. Save the **FIRA** (Foreign Inward Remittance Advice) for every payment — it is your proof for tax and GST.

Website	Best for	Fee signal	FIRA	Note
Payoneer	Upwork, Fiverr, Testlio, GoTranscript	~2% FX spread + withdrawal fee	Free digital, 24–72 hr	Native with marketplaces
Skydo	Direct invoices of \$1,000+	Flat \$19 (<\$2,000), \$29 (\$2,001–10,000), 0.3% above	Free, instant	RBI PA-CB authorised (Jan 2026)
Wise Business	Small direct invoices (<\$1,000)	~1.5–1.7% conversion	~\$2–2.50 each	Needs a business account to receive in India
Xflow	Direct clients	Flat / low fee	Automated eFIRA	RBI PA-CB authorised (Feb 2026)
Bank wire (SWIFT)	Companies that only wire	Intermediary fees + bank FX spread	Bank request, ₹200–500 each	Slow, hidden charges
PayPal	Rev, UserTesting, last resort	Rate ~3–4% below mid-market	—	Usually the most expensive

Skydo's own comparison puts the cost of receiving a \$3,000 invoice at ~\$34 (Skydo), ~\$60 (Payoneer), ~\$61 (Wise), ~\$223 (Stripe), ~\$261 (PayPal). Most fee details here come from vendor blogs — check live pricing before signing up.

For every direct client

- ☐ Invoice in USD/EUR with your name, PAN and address (plus “Export of services under LUT” if GST-registered)
- ☐ Correct purpose code — software services usually use P0802; confirm with your payment provider
- ☐ Download each FIRA into a yearly folder
- ☐ Make sure the money reaches India within 9 months of the invoice date (Section 23)

23. Tax & compliance — 2026 rules

This is general information, not tax advice. Confirm with a chartered accountant once your income starts.

Income tax

- Money from foreign clients is **taxable income in India**. File your ITR at incometax.gov.in even if no tax is due.
- **New Act:** the Income-tax Act, 2025 applies from 1 April 2026 and uses “Tax Year” (e.g. Tax Year 2026-27) ([TaxGuru](#)).
- **Presumptive scheme:** the old Section 44ADA now sits in Section 58 of the new Act. Only 50% of gross receipts is treated as income, no books needed; limit ₹50 lakh, or ₹75 lakh if cash receipts are ≤5% ([Treelife](#)). Software freelancers usually qualify as “technical consultancy” — confirm with your CA.
- **New regime:** taxable income up to ₹12 lakh → zero tax via the Section 87A rebate (₹60,000); FY 2026-27 slabs unchanged ([BankBazaar](#)). Example: ₹20 lakh of freelance receipts under the presumptive scheme = ₹10 lakh taxable = zero tax (if you have no other income).
- **Advance tax** is due if your tax exceeds ₹10,000 a year; presumptive-scheme taxpayers can pay it all by 15 March.
- **US clients:** fill in form W-8BEN so 30% isn't withheld in the US; if any foreign tax is deducted, claim credit in India with Form 67.
- **Crypto:** see Section 16 — 30% tax on gains when you sell, 1% TDS, no loss set-off.

GST

- Work for foreign clients is **export of services — 0% GST** ([Xflow](#)).
- Registration is mandatory only above ₹20 lakh aggregate turnover (₹10 lakh in special-category states); exports count towards it.
- Once registered, file an LUT (Form RFD-11) each financial year and invoice without IGST; report exports in GSTR-1 Table 6A and GSTR-3B. Keep FIRA + LUT + invoices.

FEMA — new from 1 October 2026

- After RBI's 22 September 2026 amendment, payment for exported services must reach India **within 9 months of the invoice date** (12 months if invoiced/settled in INR) ([TaxGuru](#)). Older articles saying 15 months are out of date.
- SOFTEX is gone; service exporters file an EDF (Export Declaration Form) within 30 days after the end of the invoice month — one EDF can cover a whole month. Entries for invoices up to ₹10 lakh can be closed on your own declaration.
- Ask your bank / payment provider and CA how the EDF applies to an individual freelancer — banks are still publishing their new procedures.

Compliance checklist

- ☐ Separate bank account for freelance income; every invoice + FIRA + platform statement saved by year
- ☐ GST registration + LUT as turnover approaches ₹20 lakh
- ☐ Advance tax date in your calendar; business/professional income in the right ITR form (often ITR-4 for presumptive, else ITR-3)
- ☐ One session with a CA in your first year

24. Scams & red flags

One rule: a **“job” that asks you for money is not a job**. India's biggest online job fraud is the “task scam” — small WhatsApp/Telegram tasks pay ₹200–500, then people lose lakhs on “prepaid tasks” ([SurveyHeart](#)). Developers face extra traps.

Red flag	What happens	What to do
Joining / training / “activation” / “prepaid task” fee	They take the money and vanish	Never pay
“HR” only on WhatsApp/Telegram; no company email or video interview	First step of a task scam	Verify the recruiter on LinkedIn and the company's official site
“Test project” repo that makes you run <code>npm install</code> or a script	Malware steals passwords and crypto wallets	Open unknown code only in a VM/container; read <code>package.json</code> scripts first
Asked to install a special “meeting app”	Malware	Use only Zoom, Google Meet or Teams
“Rent us your account” / “we'll work under your name”	Identity misuse, bans, legal risk	Refuse outright
Client overpays and asks for a refund	Overpayment / chargeback scam	Take payment only on-platform or against a clear invoice
Upwork client wants to pay off-platform	You lose payment protection; ToS violation	Stay on the platform
Huge pay for little work, “join right now”	Classic bait	Google the company + “scam”; check Glassdoor/Reddit

If you are cheated: call **1930** immediately and report at [cybercrime.gov.in](#); report the number on [Sanchar Saathi](#) ([Chakshu](#)); ask your bank to block the transactions; keep screenshots, UPI IDs and transaction IDs.

25. Plans — starter plan by level & a 90-day plan

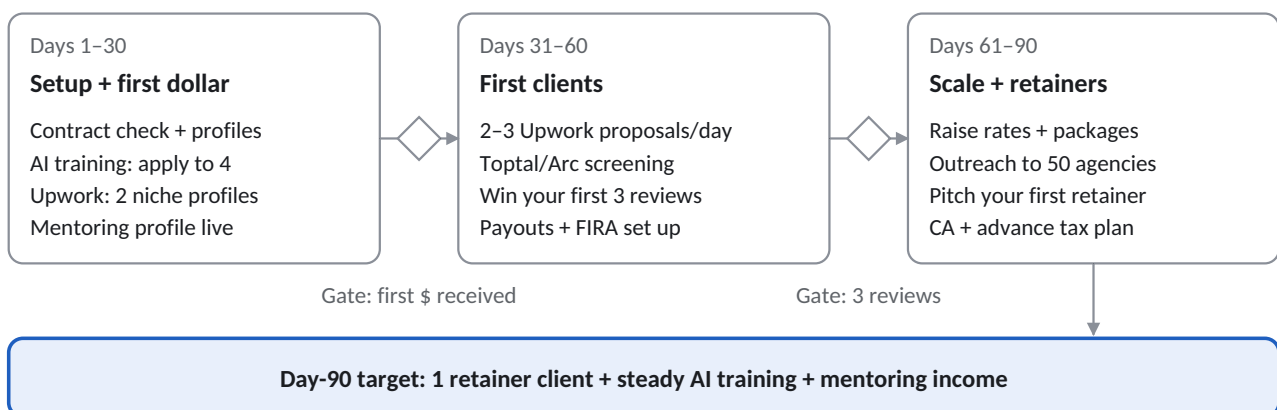
Starter plan by level

Your level	Hours/week	Do this
1st–2nd year (learning)	3–5	Build and deploy 3 projects · Hacktoberfest/GSSoC contributions · 1–2 hackathons on Devpost/MLH · start a blog · try UserTesting/uTest for small earnings
3rd–4th year / fresher	8–12	Apply to Outreachy / GSoC / Summer of Bitcoin / LFX in season · Upwork or Fiverr profile with 2 small gigs · Testlio · remote internships via Wellfound/LinkedIn · AI training if you pass the coding test · tutoring on Preply/Codingal
Working developer	10–20	Moonlighting check first · AI training for quick income · Arc/Turing/Toptal screening · Upwork with a sharp niche · mentoring on MentorCruise/Topmate · direct clients after 3–5 reviews
Non-developer (commerce, medical, law, design, languages)	5–15	Pick one service from Section 20 · earn its certification (Section 21) · build 3 samples · start on Upwork/Fiverr or a specialist board (GoTranscript, AAPC jobs, 99designs)

A 90-day plan for a working developer (part-time)

First dollar in 30 days, steady income in 90

Part-time plan, ~15–20 hr/week · a gate at the end of each phase



Move to the next phase only after passing each gate. As client work grows, cut AI-training hours — client work wins on both rate and stability.

A typical part-time week (~18 hours)	Hours	When
AI training tasks	6	Weekday nights, flexible
Upwork proposals + client work	6	8 pm–midnight IST (US overlap)
Screening prep (DSA, live coding)	3	Weekend mornings
Mentoring calls	3	Weekends

This week's checklist (everyone)

- ☐ Pick **one** path from Section 2 that matches your level — don't try everything at once
- ☐ Update GitHub/portfolio + LinkedIn; have at least 2 live samples of your work
- ☐ Create profiles on 2 websites from that section
- ☐ Open a Payoneer account in your own name; keep PAN and bank details ready
- ☐ Block fixed weekly hours in your calendar — and keep studies or your main job first

26. Sources

Checked on 4 October 2026. Fees, eligibility and programs change often — always confirm on the official website before you sign up. Where a source is a vendor blog (Skydo, Xflow), treat the numbers as indicative.

Marketplaces, networks & jobs

- [Upwork](#) — [Freelancer Service Fee](#) · [Xflow](#) — [Fiverr fees & payouts in India](#) · [Freelancer.com fees](#) · [useme](#) — [PeoplePerHour fees](#) · [FreelanceCompare](#) — [Contra](#)
- [Malt](#) — [registering from abroad](#) · [Ureed](#) — [FAQs](#) · [freelancepayouts](#) — [Upwork and Russia](#) · [Japanese-language jobs in India](#)
- [Toptal](#) — [screening](#) · [Arc](#) — [India salaries](#) · [Arc](#) — [global salaries](#) · [Arc](#) — [talent FAQ](#) · [Turing](#) — [remote AI jobs](#) · [Braintrust review](#) · [Crossover](#) — [India](#) · [Uplers](#) · [NoDesk](#) — [Lemon.io](#)
- [Himalayas](#) — [remote job boards](#) · [Deel](#) — [contractor withdrawals](#) · [CODERCOPS](#) — [white-label partnerships](#) · [GUVI](#) — [moonlighting in India](#)

AI training, testing, teaching, content

- [Outlier](#) — [India coding listing](#) · [Mercor](#) — [software engineers](#) · [howtoaijobs](#) — [AI jobs by country](#) · [ziloservices](#) — [annotation platforms](#)
- [Testlio](#) · [Test IO](#) — [uTest vs Test IO](#) · [UserTesting in India 2026](#)
- [Supatutor](#) — [Cambly requirements](#) · [Codingal](#) — [teach](#) · [BrightChamps](#) — [careers](#) · [Cuemath](#) — [tutoring jobs](#) · [Outschool](#) — [educator FAQ](#) · [Chegg expert sign-up closed](#) · [Preply tutor guide](#)
- [MentorCruise](#) — [fees](#) · [Codementor](#) — [fee](#) · [ADPList](#) — [Topmate fees](#) · [Udemy](#) — [revenue share](#) · [Karat](#) — [India](#)
- [Medium](#) — [Partner Program eligibility](#) · [DEV](#) — [paid technical writing](#) · [vidIQ](#) — [YouTube Partner Program](#) · [Google](#) — [Season of Docs ended](#)
- [GoTranscript](#) — [Indian transcription](#) · [Rev](#) — [freelancers](#) · [Voice123](#) — [Hindi voice actors](#) · [Voices.com](#) — [Indian accent](#)
- [99designs](#) — [application process](#) · [Etsy](#) — [India payments](#) · [Envato flat 50% revenue share](#)

Bounties, open source, competitions, consulting, professions

- [3university](#) — [bug bounty platforms](#) · [guptadeepak.com](#) — [bug bounty 2026](#) · [Superteam India](#) · [ClearTax](#) — [crypto tax](#)
- [Outreachy](#) — [applicant guide](#) · [Outreachy](#) — [May 2026 round](#) · [GSoC](#) — [rules](#) · [GSoC](#) — [FAQ](#) · [Summer of Bitcoin](#) — [stipend](#) · [LFX](#) — [stipends](#) · [Algora](#) · [GitHub Sponsors](#) — [regions](#)
- [Kaggle](#) · [Topcoder](#) · [Internshala competitions](#) · [Mycrolance](#) — [expert network rates](#)
- [VJM Global](#) — [US tax prep outsourcing](#) · [Miles Education](#) — [EA exam centres in India](#) · [AAPC](#) — [remote jobs](#) · [Remote CPC coder jobs India 2026](#)

Payments, tax, safety

- [Skydo](#) — [payment platforms](#) · [Skydo](#) — [fees](#) · [Xflow](#) — [Skydo vs Wise](#)
- [TaxGuru](#) — [Section 58](#) · [Treelife](#) — [presumptive taxation](#) · [BankBazaar](#) — [slabs FY 2026-27](#) · [Xflow](#) — [GST for freelancers](#) · [TaxGuru](#) — [FEMA 2026](#)
- [SurveyHeart](#) — [scam red flags](#) · [cybercrime.gov.in](#) · [Sanchar Saathi](#)